

PUPIL NAME: _____ CLASS: _____ TEACHER: _____

KEY TOPIC 1 • C1250–C1500

Medicine in Medieval England

Supernatural Dogma, The Four Humours and The Black Death Catastrophe



Primary Artifact: Medieval Physician Examining a Matula • British Library MS Harley 1585 (c. 1250) Accession Shelfmark: ARCH-MED-1250

COURSE SPECIFICATION • KEY TOPIC 1 ENQUIRY SEQUENCE

- **Key Topic 1.1: Supernatural & Religious Explanations of Disease**
Why did medieval people believe disease was sent by God, and how did the Catholic Church enforce medical dogma?
- **Key Topic 1.2: Rational Explanations: Hippocrates, Galen & The Four Humours**
How did the Four Humours and Theory of Opposites explain illness, and why were they never questioned?
- **Key Topic 1.3: Approaches to Prevention & Treatment: Bleeding, Purging & Herbal Remedies**
Why did humoral treatments such as bloodletting, purging, and Theriac remain the standard medical response?
- **Key Topic 1.4: Medical Care Providers & Monastic Hospitals: 'Care Not Cure'**
Who treated the sick in medieval England, and why did monastic hospitals focus purely on spiritual care?
- **Key Topic 1.5: Case Study: Dealing with the Black Death Catastrophe (1348–1349)**
Why were medieval people, physicians, and civic authorities completely unable to stop the Black Death?

• *Revision Tip: If you ever feel stressed about GCSE exams, just remember that in 1348 your doctor's solution would have been strapping a live toad to your chest.*

LIVING TIMELINE • PART 1: RELIGIOUS IDEAS & HUMOURAL FOUNDATIONS (C1250–C1320)

Instructions: As you study each enquiry lesson, complete the timeline missions by sketching and annotating in the corresponding Key Topic boxes below.

c. 1250 • The Church Monopoly: Galen & Monastic Scriptoria

Key Topic 1.1

Hippocrates' Four Humours and Galen's Opposites dominate medical thinking. Because Galen believed every organ was designed by a single Creator, the Church adopts his texts as sacred doctrine, controlling all manuscript copying in monastic scriptoria.

1277 • The Imprisonment of Roger Bacon (Suppression of Experimentation)

Key Topic 1.1

Franciscan friar Roger Bacon is imprisoned by Church leaders for advocating firsthand observation and scientific experiments rather than unquestioned acceptance of ancient books. This harsh punishment warns scholars that challenging Galen is heresy.

c. 1300 • The Physician's Toolkit: Uroscopy in the Matula & Zodiac Man

Key Topic 1.2

Physicians carry pocket Vademecum handbooks containing 20-shade urine charts and astrology wheels. Examining urine in a glass matula becomes the primary diagnostic method; doctors check the Zodiac Man to determine when to perform bloodletting.

c. 1320 • Humoural Therapeutics: Phlebotomy, Purging & Theriac

Key Topic 1.3

Treatments focus entirely on restoring humoral balance. Phlebotomy (bloodletting with fleams, cupping, or leeches) and purging (emetics and clysters) physically deplete patients. Apothecaries prepare Theriac (60+ ingredients including viper flesh) as a universal remedy.

• CGP Fact: Franciscan friar Roger Bacon spent 14 years in prison for suggesting doctors should test things. Stick to the syllabus and avoid 14 years in solitary confinement.

LIVING TIMELINE • PART 2: MONASTIC CARE & THE BLACK DEATH CATASTROPHE (1345–C1500)

Instructions: As you study each enquiry lesson, complete the timeline missions by sketching and annotating in the corresponding Key Topic boxes below.

c. 1350–1400 • Monastic Hospitals: The Era of 'Care Not Cure'

Key Topic 1.4

Over 1,200 hospitals run by monks and nuns operate in England (e.g. St Bartholomew's, 1123). Patients receive clean bedding, warmth, food, and continuous prayer facing a chapel altar. Zero surgery or medical cure is attempted; lepers and plague victims are strictly barred.

1345 • The Great Planetary Conjunction in Aquarius

Key Topic 1.5

In March 1345, Mars, Jupiter, and Saturn align in Aquarius. University of Paris physicians state this celestial conjunction drew up poisonous vapours from the earth, corrupting the air with deadly miasma, preparing Europe for the Black Death.

1348 • The Black Death Reaches Melcombe Regis, Dorset

Key Topic 1.5

In June 1348, the pestilence arrives on trade ships carrying black rats and fleas. The dual epidemic—bubonic plague (flea bites, agonizing buboes) and pneumonic plague (airborne coughing droplets)—kills 30–50% of England's population within 18 months.

1349 • King Edward III's Cleanliness Order & East Smithfield Mass Pits

Key Topic 1.5

Alarmed by rotting waste and stench, Edward III orders London streets cleared of dung to remove miasma. Churchyards overflow; emergency mass burial trenches are dug outside city walls at East Smithfield to bury hundreds of corpses daily.

• Exam Insight: King Edward III ordered Londoners to clean human filth off the streets in 1349. Outstanding for civic smell, totally useless against *Yersinia pestis* fleas.

• 'DO NOW' RETRIEVAL DRILL (10 RECALL QUESTIONS)

Score: [/ 10]

1. Which ancient Greek physician is known as the 'Father of Medicine'?

3. Name the four bodily humours identified by Hippocrates.

5. Which ancient Roman physician expanded this into the Theory of Opposites?

7. Why did Galen dissect pigs and apes instead of human corpses?

9. What was the ethical pledge written by Hippocrates taken by doctors?

2. In which century BC did Hippocrates live and teach?

4. What term describes Hippocrates' method of observing symptoms at the bedside?

6. In which century AD did Galen live and practise in Rome?

8. What Latin term refers to foul-smelling air believed to cause epidemic disease?

10. What term describes explaining natural events through God or spirits?

• KEY VOCABULARY TASK

TERMINOLOGY

Define **Divine Retribution** and explain how it differed from a **Planetary Conjunction** as an explanation of disease:

• QUESTION 3(A): EXPLAIN ONE SIMILARITY [4 MARKS]

[4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which ideas about the cause of disease in the Medieval period (c1250–c1500) were similar to ideas in the Renaissance period (c1500–c1700). [4 marks]

Hint: Focus on the persistent belief that epidemics (such as the 1348 Black Death and the 1665 Great Plague) were sent by God to punish human sin.

Stems: One way ideas were similar was the continued belief in divine punishment... • In the Medieval period... • Similarly, in the Renaissance...

• QUESTION 3(B): EXPLAIN ONE DIFFERENCE [4 MARKS]

[4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which ideas about the cause of disease in the Medieval period (c1250–c1500) were different from ideas in the Modern period (c1900–present). [4 marks]

Hint: Contrast medieval supernatural beliefs (God, sin, and astrology) with the modern scientific understanding of microscopic pathogens (bacteria and viruses).

Stems: One way ideas differed was the understanding of causes... • In the Medieval period, people believed... • In contrast, in the Modern period...

EXTENDED WRITING ASSESSMENT

Stimulus:

The imprisonment of Roger Bacon (1277)

STRUCTURE STRIP • 3-PARAGRAPH ANALYTICAL PLAN

Explain how the Church accepted Christian astrology (1345 planetary alignment); without printing or dissection, ordinary people had zero alternative explanations.

divine retribution • biblical leprosy • Lazar houses • teleology • heresy • Roger Bacon (1277) • monastic scriptoria • 1345 planetary conjunction • astrological almanacs

← Pages 2-3

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• 'DO NOW' RETRIEVAL DRILL (10 RECALL QUESTIONS)

Score: [/ 10]

1. Why did the medieval Catholic Church support Galen's medical writings?

2. Name the Franciscan friar imprisoned in 1277 for advocating scientific experimentation.

3. Where were all medical books hand-copied during the Middle Ages?

4. What was considered the primary supernatural cause of disease in medieval Europe?

5. What special hospitals were built outside town walls to isolate lepers?

6. What astrological event in 1345 was blamed for corrupting the atmosphere?

7. Which Greek doctor originated the Theory of the Four Humours?

8. Which Roman doctor wrote treatises that became unquestioned Church dogma?

9. What Latin term was used for religious beliefs that contradicted Church doctrine?

10. Name the English pilgrimage destination famous for the shrine of Thomas Becket.

• KEY VOCABULARY TASK

TERMINOLOGY

Define **Humoural Imbalance** and explain how it differed from **Miasmatic Corruption**:

• QUESTION 3(A): EXPLAIN ONE SIMILARITY [4 MARKS]

[4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which rational ideas about the cause of disease in the Medieval period were similar to ideas in the Renaissance period. [4 marks]

Hint: Focus on the persistent reliance on miasma (foul-smelling air from swamps and filth) among both physicians and ordinary people across both eras.

Stems: One way rational ideas were similar was the continued belief in miasma... • In the Medieval period... • Similarly, in the Renaissance...

• QUESTION 3(B): EXPLAIN ONE DIFFERENCE [4 MARKS]

[4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which methods of diagnosing illness in the Medieval period were different from methods of diagnosis in the Modern period. [4 marks]

Hint: Contrast medieval physicians inspecting urine in a glass matula and checking zodiac charts with modern laboratory blood tests, X-rays, and scans.

Stems: One way methods of diagnosis differed was... • In the Medieval period, doctors relied on... • In contrast, in the Modern period...

• *Uroscopy Masterclass: 20 shades on the urine wheel, and physicians regularly smelled, held up, and tasted the sample. Truly, the golden age of medical diagnostic dignity.*

EXTENDED WRITING ASSESSMENT

Stimulus: Galen's Theory of Opposites The diagnostic matula (uroscopy) *(You must also use information of your own)*

Four Humours • Theory of Opposites • blood (sanguine) • phlegm (phlegmatic) • yellow bile (choleric) • black bile (melancholic) • uroscopy • matula flask • Vademecum • Zodiac Man

← Pages 2-3

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• 'DO NOW' RETRIEVAL DRILL (10 RECALL QUESTIONS)

Score: [/ 10]

1. Which bodily humour was associated with spring, air, and a warm, moist temperament?

2. Which bodily humour was associated with winter, water, and a cold, moist temperament?

3. According to Galen's Theory of Opposites, how should a cold, moist fever be treated?

4. What glass flask did medieval physicians hold up to the light to examine urine?

5. What chart matched urine colour, sediment, and clarity against 20 shades?

6. What pocket handbook containing medical and astrological charts did physicians carry?

7. What diagram showed which star signs governed different parts of the human body?

8. Why did physicians check the moon's position before performing surgery or bleeding?

9. Who controlled all medical learning and universities in medieval England?

10. What Latin medical curriculum was read by university students without patient contact?

• KEY VOCABULARY TASK

TERMINOLOGY

Define **Phlebotomy (Bloodletting)** and explain how it differed from **Purging (Emetics & Clysters)**:

• QUESTION 3(A): EXPLAIN ONE SIMILARITY [4 MARKS]

[4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which approaches to medical treatment in the Medieval period were similar to approaches to treatment in the Renaissance period. [4 marks]

Hint: Focus on the persistent reliance on humoral bloodletting and herbal infusions among ordinary households, despite elite debates.

Stems: One way treatments were similar was the continued reliance on bloodletting... • In the Medieval period... • Similarly, in the Renaissance...

• QUESTION 3(B): EXPLAIN ONE DIFFERENCE [4 MARKS]

[4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which medical treatments in the Medieval period were different from treatments in the Renaissance period. [4 marks]

Hint: Contrast medieval herbal Theriacs and humoral bleeding with new Renaissance chemical remedies pioneered by Paracelsus (e.g. antimony, mercury).

Stems: One way medical treatments differed was... • In the Medieval period, doctors relied on... • In contrast, in the Renaissance...

Explain why humoral treatments such as bloodletting and purging remained the standard medical response to illness throughout the Middle Ages (c1250–c1500). [12 marks]

Stimulus: **Phlebotomy (bloodletting)** **The Regimen Sanitatis** *(You must also use information of your own)*

STRUCTURE STRIP • 3-PARAGRAPH ANALYTICAL PLAN

1. HUMOURAL DRAINING

Explain how doctors believed excess blood caused fevers and inflammation; describe methods (fleams into veins, cupping, live leeches) and why patients felt psychosomatic relief.

2. PURGING THE DIGESTIVE TRACT

Explain how emetics (inducing vomiting) and laxatives/enemas (clysters) were used to violently clear corrupted humours from the stomach and intestines.

3. HERBAL THERIACS & REGIMEN

Explain how apothecaries compounded antidotes like Theriac (60+ ingredients) and how physicians advised rich patients to follow the Regimen Sanitatis (diet, exercise, rest).

ANALYTICAL CONNECTIVES:

One major reason bloodletting was so widespread was... • Furthermore, physicians believed that purging... • Crucially, herbal remedies like Theriac... • Because these treatments aligned with Galenic theory... • Consequently...

KEY VOCABULARY BANK:

phlebotomy (bloodletting) • fleam • scarification • cupping • leeches (Hirudo medicinalis) • purging • emetics • clyster (enema) • Theriac • Regimen Sanitatis • pilgrimages • relics

TIMELINE MISSION

Turn to Pages 2–3 (Key Topic 1.3). In the drawing box, draw a barber-surgeon's bleeding bowl, fleam, and leeches. Write a 2-sentence explanation of how bloodletting was believed to restore humoral balance.

← **Pages 2–3**

• *Apothecary Special: Medieval Theriac contained 64 ingredients, including mashed vipers and raw opium. If it didn't cure your fever, at least you stopped caring.*

• 'DO NOW' RETRIEVAL DRILL (10 RECALL QUESTIONS)

Score: [/ 10]

1. Name three methods used by medieval practitioners to draw blood during phlebotomy.

2. What ancient herbal compound contained over 60 ingredients including viper flesh?

3. What Latin lifestyle guide advised medieval elites on diet, sleep, and bathing?

4. What pointed surgical instrument was used by barber-surgeons to cut into a vein?

5. What was the function of an emetic in medieval medicine?

6. What long syringe was used by medieval practitioners to administer herbal enemas?

7. Name two religious treatments medieval people used to seek healing.

8. What is the difference between humoural imbalance and miasma?

9. Which ancient Greek doctor developed clinical observation and the Four Humours?

10. Which ancient Roman physician originated the Theory of Opposites?

• KEY VOCABULARY TASK

TERMINOLOGY

Define **Monastic Hospital 'Care'** and explain how it differed from Modern Hospital **Medical 'Cure'**:

• QUESTION 3(A): EXPLAIN ONE SIMILARITY [4 MARKS]

[4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which the types of medical practitioners available to ordinary people in the Medieval period were similar to those in the Renaissance period. [4 marks]

Hint: Focus on the continuous reliance on barber-surgeons for tooth-pulling and bloodletting, apothecaries for herbs, and wise women for home remedies.

Stems: One way practitioners were similar was ordinary people's reliance on... • In the Medieval period... • Similarly, in the Renaissance...

• QUESTION 3(B): EXPLAIN ONE DIFFERENCE [4 MARKS]

[4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which hospital care in the Medieval period was different from hospital care in the 18th or 19th century. [4 marks]

Hint: Contrast medieval monastic hospitals run by nuns offering rest and prayer without doctors, with 18th/19th century voluntary hospitals employing trained doctors to cure disease.

Stems: One way hospital care differed was... • In the Medieval period, hospitals... • In contrast, in the 18th and 19th centuries...

EXTENDED WRITING ASSESSMENT

Stimulus: **The role of monks and nuns** **The exclusion of infectious patients** *(You must also use information of your own)*

1. RELIGIOUS FOUNDATIONS Explain how over 1,200 hospitals were monastic charities; their purpose was hospitium (hospitality, warmth, food, clean sheets, and prayer facing a chapel altar).	2. ABSENCE OF PHYSICIANS Explain how hospitals were staffed by monks and nuns rather than university physicians; doctors were expensive, surgery was prohibited to clergy, and no cures existed.	3. PATIENT EXCLUSION Explain why hospitals strictly turned away lepers, plague victims, and terminal cases to preserve spiritual peace, redirecting lepers to separate Lazar houses.
ANALYTICAL CONNECTIVES: <i>A central reason medieval hospitals focused on care not cure was... • In particular, monasteries established hospitals to... • Furthermore, university-trained physicians were absent because... • Crucially, infectious patients were turned away because... • Consequently...</i> KEY VOCABULARY BANK: 'care not cure' • hospitium • St Bartholomew's (1123) • Augustinian nuns • chapel altar • university physician • barber-surgeon • apothecary • wise woman • Guild of Surgeons (1368) • Lazar houses		

[illegible]

← Pages 2-3

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• 'DO NOW' RETRIEVAL DRILL (10 RECALL QUESTIONS)

Score: [/ 10]

1. State the motto or philosophy of medieval monastic hospitals regarding patient treatment.

2. Name two groups of patients strictly excluded from medieval monastic hospitals.

3. Which religious figures actually staffed and operated medieval hospitals?

4. Which medical practitioners performed bloodletting, tooth-pulling, and minor surgery?

5. Why were university-trained physicians inaccessible to ordinary peasants?

6. Where did ordinary villagers turn for herbal salves, charms, and childbirth help?

7. Which medical guild was formally established in London in 1368?

8. In what year was London's famous St Bartholomew's Hospital founded?

9. Why were hospital beds arranged to face directly toward the chapel altar?

10. In what Dorset port did the Black Death first arrive in England in June 1348?

• KEY VOCABULARY TASK

TERMINOLOGY

Define **Bubonic Plague** and explain how it differed from **Pneumonic Plague** in transmission and mortality:

• QUESTION 3(A): EXPLAIN ONE SIMILARITY [4 MARKS]

[4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which attempts to prevent the spread of the Black Death (1348) were similar to attempts to prevent the Great Plague of London (1665). [4 marks]

Hint: Focus on the continued reliance on lighting bonfires in the streets, carrying sweet herbs to ward off miasma, and prayer to appease God's wrath.

Stems: One way attempts to prevent spread were similar was... • During the Black Death in 1348... • Similarly, during the Great Plague of 1665...

• QUESTION 3(B): EXPLAIN ONE DIFFERENCE [4 MARKS]

[4 MARKS • 5 MINS]

Explain one way in which civic reactions to the Black Death (1348) were different from civic reactions to the Great Plague (1665). [4 marks]

Hint: Contrast the absence of organized municipal quarantine in 1348 with the strict house lockdowns, red crosses on doors, and watchmen enforced in 1665.

Stems: One way civic reactions differed was... • During the Black Death in 1348... • In contrast, during the Great Plague of 1665...

• *Plague Prevention (1348): Carrying a posy of dried lavender and sniffing vinegar won't stop flea bites, but at least London streets smelled slightly more tolerable.*

Stimulus: **Punishment from God** **Miasma (bad air)** *(You must also use information of your own)*

The Black Death (1348–49) • Melcombe Regis • *Yersinia pestis* • bubonic plague (rat fleas) • pneumonic plague (cough droplets) • buboes • 30–50% mortality • flagellants • sweet posies • street fires • Edward III (1349) • East Smithfield plague pits

← Pages 2-3

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STUDENT ASSESSMENT RECORD & PROGRESS TRACKER

PUPIL NAME: _____ CLASS: _____ TARGET GRADE: _____

Date Completed	Lesson • Specification Focus	Q3 Practice [4m]	Extended Response	Lesson Total
___ / ___ / 2026	KT1.1: Supernatural & Church	Q3 Similarity: [/ 4]	Q4 Explain Why: [/ 12]	[/ 16]
___ / ___ / 2026	KT1.2: Four Humours & Galen	Q3 Difference: [/ 4]	Q4 Explain Why: [/ 12]	[/ 16]
___ / ___ / 2026	KT1.3: Bleeding & Purging	Q3 Difference: [/ 4]	Q4 Explain Why: [/ 12]	[/ 16]
___ / ___ / 2026	KT1.4: Care & Monastic Hospitals	Q3 Difference: [/ 4]	Q4 Explain Why: [/ 12]	[/ 16]
___ / ___ / 2026	KT1.5: The Black Death 1348–49	Q3 Similarity: [/ 4]	Q5/6 Essay: [/ 20]	[/ 24]
CUMULATIVE ASSESSMENT TOTALS		Q3 Total: [/ 20]	Extended: [/ 76]	[/ 96]

TEACHER FORMATIVE ASSESSMENT • FEEDBACK

Effort: [1 • 2 • 3 • 4 • 5]

WHAT WENT WELL (WWW):

EVEN BETTER IF (EBI):

Teacher Signature: _____

Date: _____

INTERACTIVE DIGITAL QUIZZING HUB • SCAN FOR INSTANT RETRIEVAL PRACTICE

ONLINE RECALL

KT1.1

Supernatural



SCAN TO QUIZ

KT1.2

Four Humours



SCAN TO QUIZ

KT1.3

Treatments



SCAN TO QUIZ

KT1.4

Hospitals



SCAN TO QUIZ

KT1.5

Black Death



SCAN TO QUIZ

• Final Revision Motto: Unlike medieval bloodletting, scanning these quiz QR codes is 100% painless and significantly more likely to boost your survival in the exam hall.